

AUSTRALIA, HISTORY OF



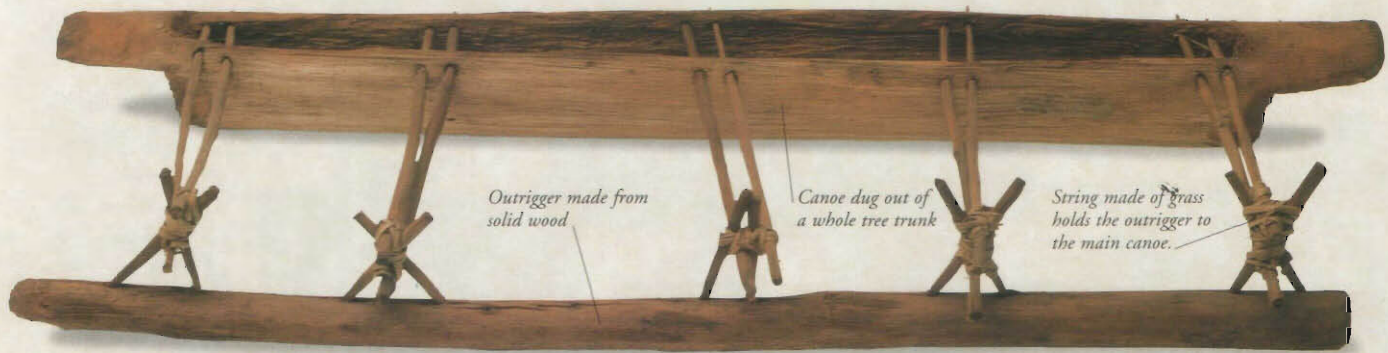
FOR MOST OF THE LAST 40,000 years, Australia was inhabited only by Aboriginal peoples. The Aboriginals were Asian in origin and created a rich culture based on hunting and food gathering. Their peaceful existence was destroyed by the arrival of Europeans in the late 18th century. The first settlers were convicts sent from crowded British prisons, but later farmers and miners drawn by the wealth of the country joined them. In 1901, Australia became an independent nation, sending troops to fight in both world wars. Today, it is a multicultural country with a rich economy and close ties with Asia, America, and Europe.

Paddles for Aboriginal canoe

First inhabitants

The first people to inhabit Australia were the ancestors of today's Aboriginals. They reached the country about 40,000 years ago after sailing across the shallow seas that then separated Australia from Asia. As sea-levels rose, they moved inland, using stone axes to clear trees to build shelters of wood and bark.

Outrigger canoe from Queensland



Outrigger made from solid wood

Canoe dug out of a whole tree trunk

String made of grass holds the outrigger to the main canoe.

Early sightings

In the 17th century, Spanish sailor Luis Vaez de Torres and Dutchman Willem Jansz explored the islands of Asia and the Pacific. Unplanned landings took place as ships were blown off course. In 1642–43 Dutchman Abel Tasman sailed round Australia without catching sight of it. He landed on an island he named Van Diemen's Land, now called Tasmania.



Early map of Australia

Botany Bay

In 1770, the British explorer Captain James Cook sailed into an inlet in southeastern Australia. He named the place Botany Bay and claimed the entire east coast of Australia for Britain. Joseph Banks, one of the ship's naturalists, sketched and collected hundreds of plants, that had never before been seen by Europeans.

Convict transportation

In 1787, the British decided to transport (ship out) convicts to Australia. The first fleet, containing 759 convicts, arrived in Botany Bay in 1788. A penal settlement was established at nearby Sydney Cove, in Port Jackson. Transportation finally came to an end in 1868.



Convicts were often used as servants.

The 19th century

Some 90 years after the arrival of Cook, the major settlements were all on the coast, and few people travelled inland. The first explorers mapped the Murray and Darling rivers in the south-east, while others tried to reach the heart of Australia.

Crossing the continent

The Royal Society of Victoria decided to send an expedition to cross the continent from south to north. Irishman Robert O'Hara Burke and Englishman William J Wills completed the trip in 1861, but died on the return journey. In July 1862 their rival, John Stuart, completed a similar journey, unaware that Burke and Wills had beaten him to it. He died in the attempt.



Gold rush

The discovery of gold in 1851 brought a rush of fortune-hunters. By 1860, the population had grown from 200,000 in 1840 to 1.1 million, and Australian gold accounted for 39 per cent of the world's total output.

Prospectors' camp, Victoria

Growth

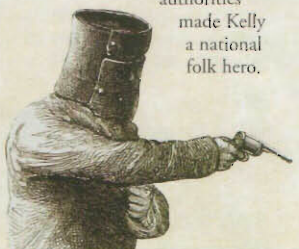
The colonies prospered in the last years of the 19th century. Industry grew quickly, especially in areas such as construction and manufacturing. Social policies were forward-thinking: for example, education for all was an early goal; trade unions were organized in many areas.

Banner for trade union



Ned Kelly

Throughout the 19th century, parts of Australia were lawless. One of the most notorious outlaws, or bushrangers, was Ned Kelly (1855–80), who led a gang of robbers. The gang killed three policemen in 1878 and robbed several banks before Kelly was caught and hanged in Melbourne in 1880. His fight against the authorities made Kelly a national folk hero.



Surveyor's chain used to measure land, 1800s